

doc-progressive-sanctification

Affirms · Soteriology › Sanctification · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · confidence: high

Statement under examination

Sanctification is the progressive, Spirit-wrought work of conforming believers to the image of Christ; distinct from justification but inseparable from it; engaged through means of grace and Spirit-empowered effort.

Rationale

Pan-canonical lexical demonstration that sanctification (ἁγιασμός *hagiasmos* G38; ἁγιάζω *hagiazō* G37; ἅγιος *hagios* G40) is a progressive Spirit-wrought work conforming the believer to the image of Christ, distinct from but flowing out of justification, engaged through means of grace and Spirit-empowered effort. The verb force is decisive: 2 Cor 3:18 μεταμορφούμεθα (*metamorphoumetha* G3339) is present passive indicative 1p, 'we are being transformed' into the same image from one degree of glory to another. Present passive aspect is unmistakably progressive; the agent is the Spirit (ἀπὸ κυρίου πνεύματος). Rom 12:2 μεταμορφοῦσθε (*metamorphousthe* G3339) is present passive imperative 2p, 'be being transformed' by the renewing (ἀνακαινώνει *anakainōsei* G342) of the mind; the imperative paired with present aspect commands ongoing transformation, not a single act. Phil 1:6 contrasts ἐναρξάμενος (*enarxamenos* G1728, aorist participle, the begun work) with ἐπιτελέσει (*epitelesei* G2005, future indicative, 'will complete') at the day of Jesus Christ: the work has a beginning, a continuation, and a future completion. Phil 3:12-14 puts the apostle himself in the progressive frame: οὐχ ὅτι ἤδη ἔλαβον (*ouch hoti ēdē elabon* G2983, 'not that I have already obtained') paired with διώκω (*diōkō* G1377, present indicative active, 'I press on / pursue') and ἐπεκτεινόμενος (*epekteinomenos* G1901, present participle, 'stretching forward'). The pursuit-language recurs in Heb 12:14 διώκετε τὸν ἁγιασμόν (*diōkete ton hagiasmon*, present imperative active 2p, 'pursue the sanctification') without which no one will see the Lord. 1 Thess 4:3 τοῦτο γὰρ ἐστὶν θέλημα τοῦ θεοῦ ὁ ἁγιασμός ὑμῶν (*touto gar estin thelēma tou theou ho hagiasmos hymōn*): God's will is your sanctification, the noun ἁγιασμός denoting the ongoing process of being set apart and made holy. 1 Thess 5:23 prays ἁγιάσαι (*hagiasai* G37, aorist optative active 3s) ὑμᾶς ὁλοτελεῖς (*holoteleis* G3651, 'completely / perfect to the end'): the optative looks toward a final-eschatological completion of what is presently in progress. Col 3:5 νεκρώσατε (*nekrōsate* G3499, aorist imperative active 2p, 'put to death') the earthly members, paired with Col 3:10 the new man being renewed (ἀνακαινούμενον *anakainoumenon* G341, present passive participle) in knowledge after the image of the one who created him: the put-off / put-on Pauline ethical pattern is the lived shape of progressive sanctification. The concordance traversal of G38 (*hagiasmos*, 10 NT occurrences: Rom 6:19, 6:22, 1 Cor 1:30, 1 Thess 4:3, 4:4, 4:7, 2 Thess 2:13, 1 Tim 2:15, Heb 12:14, 1 Pet 1:2) shows the noun consistently denoting the process of advancing in holiness, often paired with εἰς (*eis*, 'unto / toward') a goal. The concordance traversal of G37 (*hagiazō*, 28 NT occurrences) shows BOTH aspects in the canon: completed/positional sanctification (perfect participles in Acts 20:32, 26:18, 1 Cor 1:2, Heb 10:10, 'those who have been sanctified') AND progressive/ongoing sanctification (present forms in Heb 2:11, 9:13; imperatives in John 17:17, Eph 5:26, 1 Thess 5:23). The canonical pattern is 'already / not yet': believers are already set apart in Christ at conversion (positional, definitive), and are being progressively conformed to Christ's image until the day of his appearing (progressive, eschatologically complete). 1 Pet 1:15-16 commands holy conduct (γενήθητε *hagioi*, 'become / be holy') grounded in the Father's own holiness, citing Lev 11:44. Rom 6:11-14, 6:19, 6:22 ground the progressive ethical pursuit in the believer's union with Christ in his death and resurrection. The doctrine is unambiguously pan-canonical, with the noun-and-verb network (G37, G38, G40) plus the transformation-language (G3339, G341, G342) plus the pursuit-language (G1377, G1901) all converging on the same picture: progressive transformation, Spirit-empowered, terminating in final glorification. Universally affirmed across all tracked Christian lineages.

Reasoning

Verdict: when someone trusts Christ, the Holy Spirit begins a lifelong work of changing that person from the inside, making them more and more like Jesus. This change is real but slow. It is not finished at conversion. It is not finished until the believer sees Christ at his appearing. The Bible calls this work sanctification, which means being set apart and made holy. The strongest reason from Scripture is 2 Corinthians 3 verse 18. We all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another. The Greek verb for 'being transformed' is in the present tense and the passive voice, which means the action is ongoing and the believer is on the receiving end of someone else's work. Paul names that someone: this comes from the Lord who is the Spirit. The same verb in the same tense appears in Romans 12 verse 2, where Paul commands believers to be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Hebrews 12 verse 14 commands believers to pursue the holiness without which no one will see the Lord. Philippians 1 verse 6 says that he who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ. Beginning, continuation, and completion are three distinct moments in the same one work. Philippians 3 verses 12 through 14 has Paul saying about himself, not that I have already obtained this or am already perfect, but I press on. If Paul was not finished, neither is any believer alive today. The strongest counterargument from Scripture is the verses that say believers have already been sanctified, perfect-tense and finished. Hebrews 10 verse 10 says we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all. 1 Corinthians 6 verse 11 says you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified. These verses use the past-tense or completed-action form of the same word. How does the verdict handle this. The Bible holds both together. The believer is already set apart for God at conversion in a final and definitive sense, and the believer is also being progressively changed into Christ's likeness in a gradual sense. These are not two different sanctifications; they are two aspects of the one work. Theologians sometimes call this positional and progressive sanctification, but the simpler way to say it is: God has already made you his, and he is also actively making you like his Son.

Denominational landscape

This doctrine is universally affirmed across every major Christian lineage. Patristic writers from the second century onward, including Athanasius, Gregory of Nyssa, John Chrysostom, and Augustine, all teach that the Christian life is ongoing growth in holiness empowered by the Spirit; the Eastern tradition develops this into the rich doctrine of theosis or deification, where the believer participates progressively in the divine energies. The Catholic Catechism teaches sanctification as the work of grace by which the believer cooperates with the Holy Spirit and grows in habitual grace toward holiness; Catholic teaching folds the legal and the infused into one tightly-knit process. Lutheran teaching in the Augsburg Confession Article VI and the Formula of Concord affirms that faith necessarily brings forth good fruits and the new obedience, with sanctification flowing from justification but distinct from it; Lutherans guard against making sanctification the ground of justification. The Anglican 39 Articles, particularly Article 12 on good works, affirm that good works are the fruits of faith following justification and are pleasing to God; Anglican baptismal liturgy and the Book of Common Prayer regularly speak of growth in grace. The Reformed tradition in Westminster Confession Chapter 13 and Heidelberg Catechism Questions 86 through 90 teaches sanctification as a progressive Spirit-wrought work in the whole man, distinct from justification, with the believer growing in grace through means of grace until full conformity to Christ at glorification. The Anabaptist tradition emphasizes discipleship and Nachfolge (following after Christ) as the lived shape of sanctification within the believers-church framework. The Wesleyan-Methodist tradition is the locus of the most prominent in-house variant. John Wesley taught entire sanctification or Christian perfection as a second definite work of grace subsequent to justification, in which the believer is cleansed from inbred sin and brought to perfect love. This is held strongly by the Wesleyan Holiness movement, Free Methodists, Nazarenes, Salvation Army, and most classical Pentecostal denominations. Reformed-Baptist gradual-only streams reject the entire-sanctification distinctive while affirming the broader doctrine of

progressive transformation. Within Methodism itself, Christian perfection is debated and variously interpreted, with some Methodists holding the strong Wesleyan reading and others reading it as the believer's progressive growth toward love-of-God-and-neighbor without a second-blessing punctiliar event. The Pentecostal Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths affirms sanctification as both an act and a progressive work of separation from evil and consecration to God. The Eastern Orthodox tradition treats progressive sanctification under the rich category of theosis, where the believer participates in the divine energies and is gradually deified by grace, culminating eschatologically. Public-record carriers of denial of progressive sanctification as such are rare.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	Yes
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	No
Would participate if otherwise	No
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	No
Would publicly correct if otherwise	Yes

Notes

Progressive sanctification is one of the most universally-affirmed doctrines in tracked Christian lineages. Patristic, Catholic, Lutheran, Anglican, Reformed, Anabaptist, Methodist, Pentecostal, and Eastern Orthodox traditions all affirm that the Christian life involves ongoing transformation by the Spirit toward the image of Christ. The notable in-house variant is the Wesleyan-Methodist distinctive of 'entire sanctification' or 'Christian perfection' as a second definite work of grace subsequent to justification, taught by John Wesley and held by the Holiness movement and most classical Pentecostal denominations. This is debated within Methodism and rejected by Reformed-Baptist gradual-only sanctification streams; it is an in-house disagreement about the SHAPE and TIMING of sanctification, not about whether the believer is being progressively transformed. Both sides affirm that the Christian is being conformed to Christ over time; they differ on whether there is a punctiliar second-blessing experience along the way. The cult-marker bar is not crossed: progressive sanctification is universally affirmed and the Wesleyan-Reformed disagreement is not gospel-grade. `cult_marker_if_denied=false`. `would_die_for=true` because denial that the Christian life involves any ongoing pursuit of holiness collapses into antinomianism (doc-antinomianism-denial) and contradicts the explicit command of Heb 12:14, 1 Pet 1:15-16, Rom 6:11-14, and Col 3:5-17. Public-record carriers of denial include strong-reading hyper-grace movements (Joseph Prince's New Covenant Theology in its most thoroughgoing form, sometimes read as teaching that no holiness-pursuit is needed because all sins past present and future are already forgiven) and some antinomian streams within church history. Most heterodox-and-cult movements (Mormonism, Jehovah's Witnesses, Iglesia ni Cristo, Christian Science) AFFIRM their own version of progressive sanctification or moral perfection-pursuit, often with works-righteousness or perfectionist distortions; the divide is on the underlying gospel and Christology, not on whether the believer should pursue holiness. `would_publicly_correct_if_otherwise=true` because pastoral failure to teach progressive sanctification is one of the most common ways the modern church abandons new believers to stagnation. Fruit-vs-precision nuance: the lay believer who confesses 'I'm growing in Christ, slowly' has the doctrine;

the academic question of whether sanctification is positional-then-progressive, or definitive-then-progressive, or progressive-with-Wesleyan-entire-sanctification, does not change the practical confession. Brethren formation is mainstream on this doctrine; the Brethren-on-trial discipline does not flag this question.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, new_covenant_theology, progressive_covenantalism, wesleyan_holiness, eastern_theosis_framework, lutheran_simul_iustus_et_peccator

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

Competing lens verdicts

Reformed-confessional (Westminster Chapter 13, Heidelberg Q86-Q90) · Sanctification is a progressive Spirit-wrought work in the whole man, distinct from but inseparable from justification, in which the dominion of sin is broken and remaining corruption is gradually mortified through the means of grace. No second-blessing entire sanctification in this life; full conformity at glorification only.:

Lutheran (Augsburg VI, Formula of Concord III, IV) · Faith necessarily brings forth good fruits and the new obedience; sanctification flows out of justification but is distinct from it. The simul iustus et peccator framework holds that the believer remains both righteous (in Christ) and a sinner (in himself) throughout life, with progressive growth in the new obedience.:

Catholic magisterial (CCC 2000-2005) · Sanctification is the work of grace by which the baptized believer cooperates with the Holy Spirit and grows in habitual (sanctifying) grace toward holiness. The legal-forensic and the infused-transformative are folded together; the believer is genuinely made righteous through cooperation with grace.:

Wesleyan-Methodist (Wesley, Plain Account of Christian Perfection; UMC Article XI) · Sanctification is both progressive and includes a definite second work of grace (entire sanctification or Christian perfection) subsequent to justification, in which the believer is cleansed from inbred sin and brought to perfect love. The progressive growth continues after entire sanctification toward final glorification.:

Eastern Orthodox (theosis framework) · Sanctification is expressed as theosis or deification, the believer's progressive participation in the divine energies. The lifelong process is synergistic, involving cooperation between divine grace and human freedom, culminating eschatologically in deification by grace.:

Pentecostal (Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths Article 9) · Sanctification is both an act of separation from that which is evil and dedication to God, and a progressive work continuing throughout the believer's life. AG distinguishes itself from Wesleyan-Holiness Pentecostalism by not requiring entire sanctification as a definite second work.:

The lexical evidence for progressive sanctification is unambiguous and pan-canonical. The transformation-language (G3339 metamorphoō in present passive/imperative at 2 Cor 3:18, Rom 12:2; G341 anakainōō in present passive at Col 3:10; G342 anakainōsis at Rom 12:2, Titus 3:5) is conjugated specifically to encode ongoing/progressive aspect. The pursuit-language (G1377 diōkō in present imperative at Heb 12:14, present indicative at Phil 3:12-14) frames the Christian life as continuous striving. The hagiastos noun-network (G38, 10 NT occurrences) and the hagiazo verb-network (G37, 28 NT occurrences) show BOTH positional/definitive sanctification (perfect passive at Heb 10:10, aorist passives at 1 Cor 6:11) AND progressive sanctification (present forms throughout). The 'already / not yet' structure is canonical: positional sanctification at conversion, progressive sanctification throughout life, completed sanctification at the parousia (1 Thess 5:23 holoteleis). The doctrine does not require any single confessional lens. What differs across frameworks is (1) whether to call the punctiliar conversion event 'definitive sanctification' alongside justification (Reformed), or fold it into justification (Lutheran), or tie it to baptismal regeneration (Catholic), or hold for a second-blessing entire sanctification (Wesleyan-Holiness), and (2) the synergistic anthropology of the process (Catholic, Orthodox, Wesleyan more synergistic; Lutheran, Reformed more monergistic in initiation though both affirm believer-cooperation in the means of grace). Analogia scripturae is invoked because Paul, Peter, John, and Hebrews use multiple converging vocabularies. Progressive revelation factors in the move from the OT command 'be holy as I am holy' (Lev 11:44, cited 1 Pet 1:16) under Israel's covenant, to the NT promise of Spirit-empowered law-walking (Ezek 36:27) fulfilled in the new covenant, to the Pauline transformation-into-Christ's-image structure (2 Cor 3:18,

Col 3:10).

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

2Cor.3.18 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. ἡμεῖς δὲ πάντες ἀνακεκαλυμμένῳ προσώπῳ τὴν δόξαν κυρίου κατοπτριζόμενοι τὴν αὐτὴν εἰκόνα μεταμορφούμεθα ἀπὸ δόξης εἰς δόξαν; metamorphoumetha G3339 present passive indicative 1p; doxa G1391; eikōn G1504; kyrios G2962; pneuma G4151

Force. 'We all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another, as from the Lord who is the Spirit.' Metamorphoumetha is present passive: the action is ongoing, and the believer is the recipient of someone else's work. The agent is named: apo kyriou pneumatōs. The phrase 'from glory to glory' (apo doxēs eis doxan) explicitly describes a graded progression. This is the load-bearing lexical evidence for progressive sanctification.

Rom.12.2 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. μὴ συσχηματίζεσθε τῷ αἰῶνι τούτῳ ἀλλὰ μεταμορφοῦσθε τῇ ἀνακαινώσει τοῦ νοός; metamorphousthe G3339 present passive imperative 2p; anakainōsis G342; nous G3563

Force. 'Do not be conformed to this age, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind.' The same verb metamorphoō appears as a present passive imperative: the command is to undergo continuous transformation, with the renewing (anakainōsis) of the mind as the means. The believer is commanded to participate in a work that is being done to them. This is the imperative-side complement to the indicative-side of 2 Cor 3:18.

Phil.1.6 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. ὁ ἐναρξάμενος ἐν ὑμῖν ἔργον ἀγαθὸν ἐπιτελέσει ἄχρι ἡμέρας Χριστοῦ Ἰησοῦ; enarxamenos G1728 aorist middle participle; epitelesei G2005 future indicative active 3s; achri G891 preposition with genitive; hēmera G2250

Force. 'He who began (enarxamenos) a good work in you will complete (epitelesei) it until the day of Jesus Christ.' Three temporal moments in one verse: aorist participle for the past beginning, implicit present continuation, future indicative for the eschatological completion. The achri-clause (until the day of Christ) names the terminal point. The good work is identified by the surrounding context with the believer's life of faith and love; the verb-network is the canonical shape of progressive sanctification with eschatological completion.

Phil.3.12 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. οὐχ ὅτι ἤδη ἔλαβον ἢ ἤδη τετελείωμαι διώκω δὲ εἰ καὶ καταλάβω; elabon G2983 aorist active indicative 1s; teteleiōmai G5048 perfect passive indicative 1s; diōkō G1377 present indicative active 1s; katalabō G2638 aorist active subjunctive 1s

Force. 'Not that I have already obtained (elabon) or am already perfected (teteleiōmai), but I press on (diōkō) if also I may lay hold (katalabō).' Paul explicitly denies completed perfection in this life (perfect passive teteleiōmai) and substitutes present-tense pursuit (diōkō). The athletic-pursuit metaphor frames the Christian life as ongoing striving toward a goal not yet reached. This is the apostolic self-witness against perfectionism and for progressive pursuit.

Phil.3.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐν δὲ τὰ μὲν ὀπίσω ἐπιλανθανόμενος τοῖς δὲ ἔμπροσθεν ἐπεκτεινόμενος; epilanthanomenos G1950 present middle participle; epekteinomenos G1901 present middle participle

Force. 'But one thing: forgetting what lies behind and stretching forward (epekteinomenos) to what lies ahead.' Both participles are present middle: continuous self-engaged forgetting-and-stretching. Epekteinomai (stretching out fully) is an athletic-image: the runner straining toward the finish line. The progressive-pursuit frame is unmistakable.

Phil.3.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. κατὰ σκοπὸν διώκω εἰς τὸ βραβεῖον τῆς ἄνω κλήσεως τοῦ θεοῦ ἐν Χριστῷ Ἰησοῦ; skopos G4649; diōkō G1377; brabeion G1017; klēsis G2821

Force. 'I press on (diōkō) toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.' Same diōkō as v.12, repeated. Skopos (goal) and brabeion (prize) are athletic-victory terms. The terminal point is the eschatological appearance of Christ. Progressive sanctification is here framed as ordered toward an eschatological prize, not toward present-life perfection.

Heb.12.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. εἰρήνην διώκετε μετὰ πάντων καὶ τὸν ἁγιασμόν οὐ χωρὶς οὐδεὶς ὄψεται τὸν κύριον; diōkete G1377 present imperative active 2p; hagioσmos G38 accusative masculine singular

Force. 'Pursue (diōkete) peace with all and the sanctification (hagiasmon) without which no one will see the Lord.' Present imperative of the same pursuit-verb. Hagiasmos as the direct object of diōketē. The terminal warning (no one will see the Lord without it) makes the pursuit non-optional and shows that sanctification has an eschatological-visibility consequence. Canonical command for active pursuit of progressive holiness.

1Thess.4.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. τοῦτο γὰρ ἐστὶν θέλημα τοῦ θεοῦ ὁ ἁγιασμός ὑμῶν ἀπέχεσθαι ὑμᾶς ἀπὸ τῆς πορνείας; hagioσmos G38 nominative masculine singular; thelēma G2307; apechesthai G568 present middle infinitive

Force. 'This is the will of God, your sanctification (ho hagioσmos hymōn), that you abstain from sexual immorality.' Sanctification is named as the content of God's will. The infinitive apechesthai (present middle, ongoing abstention) names a concrete ethical outworking. Hagiasmos is here the ongoing process of being set apart from sexual sin and made holy.

1Thess.4.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. εἰδέναι ἕκαστον ὑμῶν τὸ ἑαυτοῦ σκεῦος κτᾶσθαι ἐν ἁγιασμῷ καὶ τιμῇ; hagioσmos G38 dative masculine singular; ktasthai G2932 present middle infinitive; timē G5092

Force. 'Each one of you knows how to control (literally 'acquire / possess') his own vessel in sanctification (en hagioσmō) and honor.' Sanctification is the sphere in which the believer's ongoing self-control occurs. Present infinitive ktasthai marks ongoing action.

1Thess.4.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. οὐ γὰρ ἐκάλεσεν ἡμᾶς ὁ θεὸς ἐπὶ ἀκαθαρσίᾳ ἀλλ' ἐν ἁγιασμῷ; hagioσmos G38 dative masculine singular; akatharsia G167; kaleō G2564

Force. 'God did not call us for impurity but in sanctification (en hagioσmō).' The divine call is structurally aimed at the believer's life-in-sanctification. The dative en marks the sphere of the calling.

1Thess.5.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. αὐτὸς δὲ ὁ θεὸς τῆς εἰρήνης ἁγιάσαι ὑμᾶς ὁλοτελεῖς καὶ ὁλόκληρον ὑμῶν τὸ πνεῦμα καὶ ἡ ψυχὴ καὶ τὸ σῶμα ἀμέμπτως ἐν τῇ παρουσίᾳ τοῦ κυρίου ἡμῶν Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ τηρηθείη; hagioasai G37 aorist optative active 3s; holoteleis G3651; parousia G3952

Force. 'May the God of peace himself sanctify (hagioasai) you completely (holoteleis), and may your whole spirit and soul and body be kept blameless at the coming (parousia) of our Lord Jesus Christ.' Aorist optative is a wish/prayer mood. Holoteleis (complete in every part) plus the parousia-clause names the eschatological-completion of what is presently in progress. This verse anchors the 'already / not yet' structure: progressive now, completed at his appearing.

Rom.6.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. λογίζεσθε ἑαυτοὺς εἶναι νεκροὺς μὲν τῇ ἁμαρτίᾳ ζῶντας δὲ τῷ θεῷ ἐν Χριστῷ Ἰησοῦ; logizesthe G3049 present middle imperative 2p; hamartia G266; zaō G2198 present active participle

Force. 'Consider (logizesthe) yourselves dead to sin and alive to God in Christ Jesus.' Present middle imperative of logizomai: ongoing reckoning of one's own union with Christ. The reckoning grounds the progressive ethical pursuit in vv.12-14.

Rom.6.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. μὴ οὖν βασιλευέτω ἡ ἁμαρτία ἐν τῷ θνητῷ ὑμῶν σώματι; basileuetō G936 present active imperative 3s

Force. 'Therefore do not let sin reign (basileuetō) in your mortal body.' Present active imperative: ongoing prohibition of sin's reign. Implies sin's continued attempts to reign and the believer's continued resistance. This is the lived ethical shape of progressive sanctification.

Rom.6.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. παραστήσατε τὰ μέλη ὑμῶν δοῦλα τῇ δικαιοσύνῃ εἰς ἁγιασμόν; parastēsate G3936 aorist active imperative 2p; hagioasmos G38 accusative masculine singular; eis preposition

Force. 'Present your members as slaves to righteousness leading to (eis) sanctification.' Eis-construction marks sanctification as the goal/outcome of yielding to righteousness. The progressive direction is from righteousness-practice toward hagioasmos-state.

Rom.6.22 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἔχετε τὸν καρπὸν ὑμῶν εἰς ἁγιασμόν τὸ δὲ τέλος ζωὴν αἰώνιον; karpos G2590; hagioasmos G38; telos G5056; zōē G2222

Force. 'You have your fruit unto sanctification (eis hagioasmon), and the end (telos) is eternal life.' Three-stage telos-structure: fruit, sanctification, eternal life. Progressive movement is built into the lexical structure of the verse.

Rom.8.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. εἰ δὲ πνεύματι τὰς πράξεις τοῦ σώματος θανατοῦτε ζήσεσθε; pneuma G4151; thanatoute G2289 present active indicative 2p; zēsesthe G2198 future middle indicative 2p

Force. 'If by the Spirit you put to death (thanatoute) the practices of the body, you will live.' Present active thanatoute (ongoing putting-to-death) by means of the Spirit (pneumati instrumental) is the inner mechanism of progressive sanctification. The Spirit is the agent; the believer is the active participant; the action is continuous.

Col.3.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. νεκρώσατε οὖν τὰ μέλη τὰ ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς πορνείαν ἀκαθαρσίαν πάθος ἐπιθυμίαν κακὴν καὶ τὴν πλεονεξίαν ἣτις ἐστὶν εἰδωλολατρία; nekṛōsate G3499 aorist imperative active 2p; porneia G4202; akatharsia G167; epithymia G1939; pleonexia G4124

Force. 'Put to death (nekṛōsate) therefore what is earthly in you.' Aorist imperative: decisive action repeated in the believer's ongoing life. The catalog of vices (sexual immorality, impurity, passion, evil desire, covetousness which is idolatry) names the concrete ethical content of the put-off side of progressive sanctification.

Col.3.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐνδυσάμενοι τὸν νέον τὸν ἀνακαινούμενον εἰς ἐπίγνωσιν κατ' εἰκόνα τοῦ κτίσαντος αὐτόν; endysamenoi G1746 aorist middle participle; anakainoumenon G341 present passive participle accusative masculine singular; epignōsis G1922; eikōn G1504

Force. 'Having put on the new man, which is being renewed (anakainoumenon) in knowledge after the image (eikōn) of the one who created him.' Present passive anakainoumenon: ongoing renewal. The eikōn-language ties back to 2 Cor 3:18 (same eikōn): the believer is being progressively renewed into the Creator's image. The lexical network is unified.

Col.3.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐνδύσασθε οὖν ὡς ἐκλεκτοὶ τοῦ θεοῦ ἅγιοι καὶ ἡγαπημένοι σπλάγχνα οἰκτιρμοῦ χρηστότητα ταπεινοφροσύνην πραῖτητα μακροθυμίαν; endysasthe G1746 aorist middle imperative 2p; hagioi G40 nominative masculine plural; chrēstotēs G5544; tapeinophrosynē G5012

Force. 'Put on therefore, as God's chosen ones, holy (hagioi) and beloved, compassionate hearts, kindness, humility, meekness, patience.' Hagioi as the believer's already-status, grounding the ethical command. Hagios G40 (the adjective behind hagiāzō and hagiastos) names the believer's set-apart identity; the imperative endysasthe names the ongoing put-on of virtues that befit it.

1Pet.1.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. κατὰ τὸν καλέσαντα ὑμᾶς ἅγιον καὶ αὐτοὶ ἅγιοι ἐν πάσῃ ἀναστροφῇ γενήθητε; hagioi G40 nominative masculine singular; genēthēte G1096 aorist passive imperative 2p; anastrophē G391

Force. 'According to him who called you, who is holy (hagion), be holy (hagioi genēthēte) yourselves in all your conduct (anastrophē).' Aorist passive imperative genēthēte: 'become / be made' holy. The believer's holy conduct is grounded in the Father's own holiness (citing Lev 11:44 in v.16). The all-conduct (en pasē anastrophē) reach makes holiness comprehensive.

1Pet.1.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. γέγραπται γάρ ἅγιοι ἔσεσθε ὅτι ἐγὼ ἅγιος; gegraptai G1125 perfect passive indicative; hagioi G40 nominative masculine plural; esesthe G1510 future indicative 2p

Force. 'For it is written, you shall be (esesthe) holy (hagioi), for I am holy.' Citation of Lev 11:44, 19:2, 20:7. The grounding of NT progressive sanctification in the OT covenant-holiness command. The future esesthe carries imperative force in citation.

Heb.10.10 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐν ᾧ θελήματι ἡγιασμένοι ἐσμέν διὰ τῆς προσφορᾶς τοῦ σώματος Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ ἐφάπαξ; hēgiasmenoi G37 perfect passive participle nominative masculine plural; ephapax G2178

Force. 'By that will we have been sanctified (hēgiasmenoi esmen, perfect passive periphrastic) through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all (ephapax).' Perfect passive: completed positional sanctification at the cross. The 'already' side of the canonical pattern. The complicating-balance to progressive verses; both aspects stand together.

1Cor.6.11 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. ἀλλὰ ἀπελούσασθε ἀλλὰ ἡγιασθητε ἀλλὰ ἐδικαιώθητε ἐν τῷ ὀνόματι τοῦ κυρίου Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ; apelousasthe G628 aorist middle indicative 2p; hēgiasthēte G37 aorist passive indicative 2p; edikaiōthēte G1344 aorist passive indicative 2p

Force. 'But you were washed, you were sanctified (hēgiasthēte), you were justified, in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ.' Three aorist passives in parallel: positional / definitive sanctification at conversion. This is the same hagiāzō verb, in a punctiliar past-event sense. Demonstrates the canonical 'already / not yet' shape: positional then progressive.

1Cor.1.30 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐξ αὐτοῦ δὲ ὑμεῖς ἐστε ἐν Χριστῷ Ἰησοῦ ὃς ἐγενήθη σοφία ἡμῖν ἀπὸ θεοῦ δικαιοσύνη τε καὶ ἁγιασμός καὶ ἀπολύτρωσις; hagiastos G38 nominative masculine singular

Force. 'From him you are in Christ Jesus, who became to us wisdom from God, righteousness and sanctification (hagiasmos) and redemption.' Christ himself is named as our sanctification. The Christ-centeredness of sanctification: it is not the believer's autonomous moral achievement but a benefit located in union with Christ.

2Thess.2.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. εἴλατο ὑμᾶς ὁ θεὸς ἀπαρχὴν εἰς σωτηρίαν ἐν ἁγιασμῷ πνεύματος καὶ πίστει ἀληθείας; hagiastos G38 dative masculine singular; pneuma G4151 genitive

Force. 'God chose you as firstfruits for salvation, in sanctification of the Spirit (en hagiasmō pneumatō) and faith of truth.' Sanctification is explicitly tied to the Spirit (pneumatōs genitive of source/agent). The Spirit is the agent of the ongoing hagiasmos process.

1Pet.1.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. κατὰ πρόγνωσιν θεοῦ πατρὸς ἐν ἁγιασμῷ πνεύματος εἰς ὑπακοὴν καὶ ῥαντισμὸν αἵματος Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ; hagiastos G38 dative masculine singular; prognōsis G4268; hypakoē G5218

Force. 'According to the foreknowledge of God the Father, in the sanctifying work of the Spirit (en hagiasmō pneumatō), for obedience and sprinkling of the blood of Jesus Christ.' Same Spirit-genitive construction as 2 Thess 2:13. The Trinity is in view: the Father foreknew, the Spirit sanctifies, the Son's blood was sprinkled. Progressive sanctification is the Spirit's role in the Trinitarian economy of salvation.

John.17.17 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. ἁγιάσον αὐτοὺς ἐν τῇ ἀληθείᾳ ὁ λόγος ὁ σὸς ἀλήθειά ἐστιν; hagiason G37 aorist active imperative 2s; alētheia G225; logos G3056

Force. 'Sanctify (hagiason) them in the truth; your word is truth.' Jesus' high-priestly prayer for the disciples' ongoing sanctification through the word. Names the instrumental means: the truth of God's word. Confirms that sanctification is a divine work the Father is asked to do, not a self-generated moral achievement.

Eph.5.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἵνα αὐτὴν ἁγιάσῃ καθάρισας τῷ λουτρῷ τοῦ ὕδατος ἐν ῥήματι; hagiase G37 aorist active subjunctive 3s; katharisas G2511 aorist active participle; loutron G3067; rhēma G4487

Force. 'That he might sanctify (hagiase) her, having cleansed her by the washing of water with the word.' Christ's purpose-clause for the church: to sanctify her. The instrumental phrase tō loutrō tou hydatos en rhēmati identifies the means as the word-mediated cleansing. Christ's bridegroom-action is to progressively sanctify the church until presentation.

Lev.11.44 · **for** · genre: law

Key term. יִגַּד שׁוֹדֵק יֵכֶּה בְּשִׁדְקוֹתָיו כִּי־הוּא הוֹדֵי יִגַּד יֵכֶּה; qadash H6942 hithpael perfect 2mp; qadosh H6918

Force. 'For I am the LORD your God; sanctify yourselves and be holy (qedoshim), for I am holy.' Old Testament foundation cited by 1 Pet 1:15-16. The hithpael of qadash carries reflexive/self-engaged force: 'consecrate yourselves.' Establishes the canonical pattern: the holiness of God grounds the holiness commanded of his people.

Ezek.36.27 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key term. וְנָתַן רוּחִי בָּכֶם וְהָלַכְתֶּם בְּחֻקֵּי יְהוָה; ruach H7307; natan H5414 qal perfect 1cs

Force. 'I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes.' New-covenant promise. The Spirit-inwardness produces ongoing law-walking. Anchors the NT teaching that progressive sanctification is Spirit-empowered, fulfilling the new-covenant promise of Jer 31 / Ezek 36.

Jude.1.20 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. ὑμεῖς δὲ ἀγαπητοὶ ἐποικοδομοῦντες ἑαυτοὺς τῇ ἀγιωτάτῃ ὑμῶν πίστει ἐν πνεύματι ἁγίῳ προσευχόμενοι; epikodomountes G2026 present active participle; hagiōtatos G40 superlative; proseuchomenoi G4336 present middle participle

Force. 'But you, beloved, building yourselves up (epikodomountes) in your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Spirit.' Present participle epikodomountes: ongoing self-edification within the holy-faith framework, Spirit-empowered. The verbal aspect frames Christian life as continuous building-up, the architecture of progressive sanctification.

2Pet.3.18 · **for** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key term. αὐξάνετε δὲ ἐν χάριτι καὶ γνώσει τοῦ κυρίου ἡμῶν καὶ σωτῆρος Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ; auxanete G837 present active imperative 2p; charis G5485; gnōsis G1108

Force. 'But grow (auxanete) in grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.' Present active imperative auxanete: ongoing organic growth. The verb is the same one used for plant-growth and child-growth: the Christian life is biologically-figurative growth in grace and knowledge.

Concordance lemmas traversed

G38, G37, G40, G3339, G341, G342, G1377, G1901, G2005, G1728, G2983, G5048, G2638, G4649, G1017, G3499, G2289, G1746, G837, G2026, G3651, G3952, G2178, G628, G1344, G3936, G2590, G5056, G2222, G1922, G1504, G1391, G4151, G2962, H6942, H6918, H7307, H5414

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Athanasius, De Incarnatione, ca. AD 318; Gregory of Nyssa, De Vita Moysis, ca. AD 390; CCEL NPNF Series 2 · **affirms · **unverified****

“Gregory of Nyssa's epektasis doctrine: the soul's perpetual stretching forward into God's infinite goodness, drawing on Phil 3:13 epekteinomenos. Athanasius: God became man so that we might be deified by grace.”

catholic_magisterial · Catechism of the Catholic Church 2000-2005, 1996-1999; vatican.va · **affirms · **verified****

“Habitual grace, the permanent disposition to live and act in keeping with God's call, is distinguished from actual graces which refer to God's interventions, whether at the beginning of conversion or in the course of the work of sanctification.”

lutheran · Augsburg Confession Article VI on New Obedience; Formula of Concord III, IV; bookofconcord.org · affirms · verified

“This faith is bound to bring forth good fruits, and it is necessary to do good works commanded by God, because of God's will, but we should not rely on those works to merit justification before God.”

anglican · 39 Articles of Religion, Article XII on Good Works, Article XVI on Sin after Baptism; Book of Common Prayer · affirms · unverified

“Good works, which are the fruits of faith and follow after justification, cannot put away our sins, yet are they pleasing and acceptable to God in Christ, and do spring out of a true and lively faith.”

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith Chapter 13, Of Sanctification, AD 1646; Heidelberg Catechism Q86-Q90 · affirms · unverified

“They who are effectually called and regenerated are further sanctified, really and personally, through the virtue of Christ's death and resurrection, by His Word and Spirit dwelling in them. This sanctification is throughout, in the whole man, yet imperfect in this life.”

methodist · Wesley, A Plain Account of Christian Perfection, AD 1777; UMC Articles of Religion (Wesley's abridgement of the 39 Articles) · affirms · verified

“Sanctification is that renewal of our fallen nature by the Holy Ghost, received through faith in Jesus Christ, whose blood of atonement cleanseth from all sin. Wesleyan distinctive adds entire sanctification as second work of grace.”

anabaptist · Mennonite tradition; Schleithem Confession 1527; Confession of Dordrecht 1632 · affirms · unverified

“Anabaptist tradition affirms progressive sanctification through Nachfolge (following after Christ), the discipleship-shaped Christian life within the believers-church, with visible holiness as the mark of genuine faith.”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God, Statement of Fundamental Truths, Article 9 on Sanctification · affirms · unverified

“Sanctification is an act of separation from that which is evil and dedication to God; the Scriptures teach a life of holiness without which no man shall see the Lord. By the power of the Holy Spirit we are able to obey.”

eastern_orthodox · Eastern Orthodox doctrine of theosis; patristic-Eastern tradition through Athanasius, Maximus the Confessor, Gregory Palamas; OCA Orthodox Faith Volume IV · affirms · unverified

“Theosis is becoming by grace what God is by nature, the believer's progressive participation in the divine energies. The Christian life is synergistic cooperation between divine grace and human freedom, culminating in deification.”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongsgreek/38.htm>

“G38 hagioσmos: from hagiozo; properly purification, i.e. purity; concretely a purifier. Ten NT occurrences: Rom 6:19, 6:22, 1 Cor 1:30, 1 Thess 4:3, 4:4, 4:7, 2 Thess 2:13, 1 Tim 2:15, Heb 12:14, 1 Pet 1:2.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongsgreek/37.htm>

“G37 hagiozo: to make holy, to purify or consecrate, to sanctify. 28 NT occurrences spanning perfect-participle positional sanctification and present-form progressive sanctification.”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/2_corinthians/3-18.htm

“metamorphoumetha G3339 present passive indicative 1p: 'we are being transformed' into the same image from one degree of glory to another, from the Lord who is the Spirit. Progressive aspect explicit.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/romans/12-2.htm>

“metamorphousthe G3339 present passive imperative 2p: 'be being transformed' by the renewing (anakainosis G342) of the mind. Imperative paired with continuous aspect commands ongoing transformation.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/philippians/1-6.htm>

“enarxamenos G1728 aorist participle (began) paired with epiteleseis G2005 future indicative (will complete) until the day of Jesus Christ. Beginning, ongoing, eschatological completion structure.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/philippians/3-12.htm>

“Paul: ouch hoti ede elabon (not that I already obtained), dioko (G1377 present indicative I press on) if I may lay hold. Apostolic self-witness against perfectionism and for progressive pursuit.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/hebrews/12-14.htm>

“diokete G1377 present imperative active 2p ton hagiasmon G38: pursue the sanctification, without which no one will see the Lord. Direct command for ongoing pursuit of progressive holiness.”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_thessalonians/4-3.htm

“touto gar estin thelema tou theou ho hagiasmos hymon: this is the will of God, your sanctification. Hagiasmos G38 noun for ongoing process of being set apart and made holy.”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_thessalonians/5-23.htm

“hagiasai G37 aorist optative active 3s: may God sanctify you completely (holoteleis G3651), kept blameless at the parousia. Prayer for eschatological completion of presently-progressive sanctification.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/colossians/3-5.htm>

“nekrosate G3499 aorist imperative active 2p: put to death the earthly members. Decisive imperative repeated in the believer's ongoing life; vice-catalog names concrete ethical content.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/romans/6-19.htm>

“parastesate G3936 ta mele eis hagiasmon G38: present your members to righteousness leading to sanctification. Eis-construction marks sanctification as goal of progressive righteousness-practice.”

supports · category: magisterial · https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/___P6Z.HTM

“Habitual grace, the permanent disposition to live and act in keeping with God's call, is distinguished from actual graces in the course of the work of sanctification. (CCC 2000)”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/of-new-obedience/>

“Augsburg VI: faith is bound to bring forth good fruits, and it is necessary to do good works commanded by God, because of God's will, but not to merit justification.”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“UMC Article XI on Sanctification: Sanctification is that renewal of our fallen nature by the Holy Ghost, received through faith in Jesus Christ, whose blood of atonement cleanseth from all sin.”